Interview Transcription:

Interaction between the **Secretary of Aayam Drama Society, Siddharth Sahu,** with **Amit Kumar Patra, Jatin Bhardwaj, DEVI VRINDA A, and SHIBIN MOHAMMED N P** mainly in Hindi and some parts in English via Gmeet.

Amit Kumar Patra: Hello, I am Amit Kumar Patra from IIT Madras, pursuing

the Data Science course. For our software group project, we are studying how a Cultural Club operates. Before we begin, can you please introduce yourself and tell me about the cultural club you are associated with?

Siddharth Sahu: Hi, I am Siddharth, and I am the current secretary of the Aayam drama

society. If you guys don't know what drama society is, just in case. It is the storytelling society that tells stories through accents, their voices, and anything. If we tell a story that is drama, and that is the Aayam. So I am a small part of that society.

Amit Kumar Patra: Okay. Thanks for the introduction, Siddharth. Now I want to ask a question: if a new member wants to join the Aayam drama society, what is the procedure regarding this?

Siddharth Sahu: If someone is new and is interested in joining our society, first, he has to fill out the Google form regarding membership to register as a new member. After this, if he is interested, he can join our WhatsApp group for the Aayam drama society and can provide his Gmail ID to get connected with the society and its activities.

Jatin Bhardwaj: I want to ask if the membership form is available in hard copy also, or if it is available only in Google Form format?

Siddharth Sahu: We do not have a membership form in hard copy format. The membership registration is an online process, so the membership registration form is available in Google Form format. The registration process is completely online.

Jatin Bhardwaj: So, when a new member wants to join the drama society, you create a new Google form for each member's registration?

Siddharth Sahu: We have already created a specific Google form regarding registration, which is available in internet, and anyone interested in joining our society can use that same form to register as a member.

To join the Aayam Drama Society, the first requirement is that you should be a BS student at IITM. Then you need to mention why you want to join the drama society, your interrests and submit the form. After the form is submitted, we will verify your email address to see if the student is from the BS Degree from IITM. Afterwards, we will add you to the WhatsApp group and add your email ID to our Google Group.

Amit Kumar Patra: If a member, after joining the drama society, like after 2 or 3 months, wants to change their contact information, how do you do it?

Siddharth Sahu: In Google Form, there is an option to edit submitted details in the form, so that's how we manage the required changes.

Jatin Bhardwaj: If you want to switch the communication platform software from WhatsApp to some other communication platform, how do you guys manage the previous data, which is already stored in the WhatsApp software? So, how do you manage the members who are already joined in the WhatsApp Group?

Siddharth Sahu: Currently, WhatsApp is not our official communication platform. We keep a tenure report, which includes each member's Gmail ID, and we need to submit it to the UHC. Gmail is our official communication chanel and we need to manage our members' records using that.

Jatin Bhardwaj: How do you collect and store all the data that is filled out by members while filling out the registration while joining the society? How do you store and manage your club members' details?

Siddharth Sahu: When a new member fills out the registration form and submits it, we get the form in sheet format, which contains the member's details in defined titled data columns with different data filled out by the member, and we keep a copy of the sheet and make our tenure report from it afterwards. Only the Gmail ID is not changeable after filling out the form since it is going to be the same for the entire course.

Jatin Bhardwaj: If a member wants to change their WhatsApp number, how can they do it?

Siddharth Sahu: If a member wants to change their WhatsApp number, they can contact us directly, and we will do it by adding their new number and removing the old one.

Amit Kumar Patra: If a member wants to leave the drama society club, then what is the procedure to do that?

Siddharth Sahu: Currently, we do not have any specific procedure for a member who wants to leave the drama society club. The member can unsubscribe with their email ID from the Google Space of the drama society club, and can leave the WhatsApp group to leave the club. The procedure is done completely by the member; we do not perform any procedure regarding a member's departure.

Jatin Bhardwaj: As other websites maintain complete user data with a proper database, if a deletion of user data happens, it can retrieve the data fully. Is it possible on your drama society club's website?

Siddharth Sahu: No.

Jatin Bhardwaj: So if a member's details get deleted, how do you retrieve the data?

Siddharth Sahu: Data deletion is not possible in our case, as data comes from the filled-up form. We can not change or delete it without the admin's permission.

Amit Kumar Patra: Do you have specific subgroups within your group for members with the same interests? Like, if some members like comedy genre and others like thriller, do you divide them into subgroups according to their interest in genre?

Siddharth Sahu: Previously, we had 5 subgroups within our groups who were responsible for acting, directing, backstage work, etc. For different work role we had different subgroups. Since currently not many members are taking an interest in joining the group, we have now divided our group into two subgroups only. First subgroup consists of all Aayam drama society members, and the other sub group is consists of members who have at least performed or worked with us for an event, they are the core members of our Aayam drama society club.

Amit Kumar Patra: Do you guys also conduct different kinds of workshops?

Siddharth Sahu: Yes

Amit Kumar Patra: Can you please, in short, how you guys conduct these workshops?

Siddharth Sahu: When we come up with an idea for a workshop or event within our society, we have a CST team. CST is the creative strategic team that decides how the event or workshop will be conducted. Then, we reach out to the PR team, the media team, and the outreach team, and they reach out to members to conduct an event or workshop, and the required works done according to the team's speciality, like if we

want designed banners, we will reach out to the media team to complete the job. The CST team manages and looks up all the team's work and organizes the event or workshops in a successful way.

Amit Kumar Patra: Do you face any hurdles while conducting the workshop or event? What is the hardest part of conducting an event or workshop in the process?

Siddharth Sahu: The toughest part is coming up with a good idea to conduct an event or workshop, then finding the required talent to execute that idea.

Jatin Bhardwaj: How do you find the required talent while executing an idea for a workshop?

Siddharth Sahu: We do PR. We email all IITM BS students that we will conduct an event or workshop on some idea and need some individuals' participation to execute it. We also send messages to the WhatsApp group regarding the same. Mainly, we outsource talents from our core member group, which is a subgroup within our society currently.

Jatin Bhardwaj: Do you outsource individual talents from outside IITM from different colleges or local clubs?

Siddharth Sahu: Yes, we have been working on a joint project with IIT-BHU ‘s drama society on an inter-IIT Curriculum event. Currently, we are in the middle of video editing of that project.

Jatin Bhardwaj: Okay, Congratulations!

Amit Kumar Patra: When you conduct a drama, how do you book a rehearsal room, stages, sound system, and the required instruments along with it, and how do you

manage those expenses and required information for later use, and manage inventories for props and track them?

Siddharth Sahu: This is the major problem, because we do not do it. First, we do not have sponsors to book any hall or costumes. The actors and directors arrange the required props by themself since we do not have the required funding and resources.

For example, for a stage play event at IIT Madras, we have to arrange all the things, like costumes and backlight, by ourselves due to a lack of funding.

Amit Kumar Patra: For example, when you are filming a short film, will you guys provide a camera to the director, or will the director have to arrange the camera themselves?

Siddharth Sahu: No, we just use a mobile camera to film it. We just arranged it somehow to get the solution.

Jatin Bhardwaj: You mentioned that currently your society does not have a sponsorship, so have you guys tried to get sponsorship, and how did you try?

Siddharth Sahu: First, we try to see the sponsors from different who have sponsored events similar to ours. We try to get their contact information from members of different IIT ‘s societies and clubs. Then we try to find potential sponsors or companies from LinkedIn who have worked on the same idea or are willing to let us work on that idea or project, and have agreed to sponsor it.

Amit Kumar Patra: At a time, how many project you guys work on simultaneously together?

Siddharth Sahu: Currently, we work on two projects together at a maximum due to a lack of manpower.

Amit Kumar Patra: How do you manage actors so that an actor does not have to work on two different projects simultaneously at a time?

Siddharth Sahu: We do not work this way due to a lack of manpower, same actor has to work to two different projects simultaneously at a time. One project is scheduled in the morning, and the other is scheduled in the evening.

Amit Kumar Patra: How do you maintain the schedule? How do you manage all the tasks for events without conflict? Is there any specific software you use?

Siddharth Sahu: To track tasks at first, we tried to use JIRA software, but since members within our group are not finding it effective and easy to use, we no longer use that application. Now we use Google Docs or Google Calendar software to manage tasks effectively. Google Docs comes with limited access, so required to re-share the doc when an update is made inside the document.

Amit Kumar Patra: While working on a project, how do you manage who will work on which part? What software do you use to keep the record?

Siddharth Sahu: We mainly use Google Docs to record the role and responsibility while working on a project, and we use the tag feature of Google Docs to specify the responsibility for individual members.

Jatin Bhardwaj: When you guys face an issue while working on a project, like needing to buy props, or due to some issue needing to pay up a fine, or some member's personal belongings got damaged while working on a group project, in that case, how do you guys handle the situation at that time?

Siddharth Sahu: First, if we have sponsorships, we try to cover the expenses of a group project or event with that fund. In most cases, we do not have the sponsorships,

so we tried to resolve the issue within our group by splitting the required money to pay among our members. Mainly, CST team members handle this situation and split up the bill among themselves in those conflicted situations.

Amit Kumar Patra: When a change of event timings and schedule changes happen, or for any official announcement, how do you inform other members regarding it?

Siddharth Sahu: We have a website for the drama society, but not many people use that website, so we inform in cases of any changes happening using Gspace, WhatsApp, and Instagram.

Amit Kumar Patra: Who informs you when a drama competition happen, how do you guys get to know about it?

Siddharth Sahu: Our outreach team is responsible for this. They also try to gather the sponsor when we try to organize an event or workshops. They also inform the UHC team to complete the required paperwork formalities. The outreach team is responsible for giving us the resources that are available outside the drama society.

Amit Kumar Patra: How do you share participation pictures and videos after a performance, and how do you share the performance video among members?

Siddharth Sahu: Normally, we do not share our personal photos. After participation, we share photos on Gspace and Instagram. For Videos normally it gets uploaded to YouTube and Instagram. After uploading our performance video or work, we announce it on Gspace.

Jatin Bhardwaj: How do you manage funds and keep track of the record of expenses?

Siddharth Sahu: All the core team members have access to the record of expenses. When a meet-up happens, IITM BS provides us with some funds, and we need to keep the bill for the meet-up expense in document format and need to submit it to the IITM BS team to get the money back.

Amit Kumar Patra: In your Aayam Drama Society, to appoint a new secretary, how do you conduct the election?

Siddharth Sahu: We create a form and share it with core members who want to participate in the election to be a secretary and deputy secretary, can fill it out. Then the eligible candidate gets selected with some selection criteria, which is based on the group activity, with the most nominations, and must have a CGPA of at least 7.5, and must have contributed to the society. Those selected candidates can now stand for election and PR to the members' group to gather votes. Previously, we used Google Forms for the election, but now we use websites to give a vote for the election.

Amit Kumar Patra: How do you guys handle a situation when you have to perform or work on two projects simultaneously?

Siddharth Sahu: We divide the team into two different subteams, and seretary and deputy secretary manage each team separately and make sure that the performance or project is completed successfully.

Jatin Bhardwaj: Thank you, Siddharth, for this wonderful interview. We will end this interview here today.

Amit Kumar Patra: Thank you, Siddharth.

DEVI VRINDA A: Thank you, Siddharth, for your time.